Practical 9: Selecting Data

Selecting & Linking Data

Table of contents

1 Preamble 2

2 Selecting Data in Pandas 4

3 Selecting Data in DuckDB 8

4 Thinking About Joins 13

5 Joining by Attribute 15

6 Spatial Joins in Geopandas 19

7 Spatial Joins in SQL 20

8 Worked Example 20

> **Important**
>
> This practical focusses on data linkage! You will have seen quite a bit of this of these across the preceding three to four weeks, but they were picked up in an *ad-hoc* way, here we try to systematise things a bit. We're also going to look at alternatives to loading the entire data set into memory in Python: using the DuckDB driver we can perform a lot of operations 'outside' of Python's memory and processing limits while still benefiting from reproducibility (the commands are stored in the Python script) and access (we can bring the filtered, linked data into Python when we need to do so).

> **Connections**
>
> We're going to look at how data can be joined (linked) to other data using a range of techniques: pure Python (spatial and non-spatial) and SQL (non-spatial only).

0.0.1 What this practical produces

Later practicals pick up from the files saved here, so it's worth knowing what you're creating and where it goes:

File	Folder	Saved in section	Used in
London_MSOA_Names.geoparquet	data/geo	Create Borough and Regional Mappings	Practical 10
Listings_with_LA.geoparquet	data/geo	Spatial Join	Practical 10
<local-authority>-MSOA_data.geoparquet	data/geo	Create LA Data	Practical 10

1 Preamble

```
ymd  = '20260619'
city = 'London'
host = 'http://orca.casa.ucl.ac.uk'
url  = f'{host}/~jreades/data/{ymd}-{city}-listings.geoparquet'
```

```
import pandas as pd
import geopandas as gpd
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
import duckdb as db

from pathlib import Path
from time import time
```

```
from pathlib import Path
from requests import get
from functools import wraps

def check_cache(f):
    @wraps(f)
    def wrapper(src:str, dst:str, min_size=100) -> Path:
        if src.find('?') == -1:
            url = Path(src)
        else:
            url = Path(src[:src.find('?')])
        fn  = url.name  # Extract the filename
        dsn = Path(f"{dst}/{fn}") # Destination filename
        if dsn.is_file() and dsn.stat().st_size > min_size:
            print(f"+ {dsn} found locally!")
            return(dsn)
        else:
            print(f"+ {dsn} not found, downloading!")
            return(f(src, dsn))
    return wrapper

@check_cache
def cache_data(src:Path, dst:Path) -> str:
    """Downloads a remote file.
```

```
    The function sits between the 'read' step of a pandas or geopandas
    data frame and downloading the file from a remote location. The idea
    is that it will save it locally so that you don't need to remember to
    do so yourself. Subsequent re-reads of the file will return instantly
    rather than downloading the entire file for a second or n-th itme.

    Parameters
    ----------
    src : str
        The remote *source* for the file, any valid URL should work.
    dst : str
        The *destination* location to save the downloaded file.

    Returns
    -------
    str
        A string representing the local location of the file.
    """

    # Create any missing directories in dest(ination) path
    # -- os.path.join is the reverse of split (as you saw above)
    # but it doesn't work with lists... so I had to google how
    # to use the 'splat' operator! os.makedirs creates missing
    # directories in a path automatically.
    if not dst.parent.exists():
        dst.parent.mkdir(parents=True, exist_ok=True)

    # Download and write the file
    with dst.open(mode='wb') as file:
        response = get(src)
        file.write(response.content)

    print(' + Done downloading...')

    return dst.resolve()
```

```
ddir     = Path('data/clean') # non-spatial data
gdir     = Path('data/geo')   # spatial data

# The Local Authority we work with from here on; change it to
# analyse a different borough (Practical 10 expects the same one).
LA       = 'Waltham Forest'
LA_slug  = LA.lower().replace(' ','-')

# A *local* copy of the (non-spatial) listings: we want to time
# pandas and DuckDB reading data, not downloading it.
pqt      = cache_data(url.replace('.geo','.'), ddir)
```

```
+ data/clean/20260619-London-listings.parquet found locally!
```

1.1 Settings for the comparison

Over the next two sections we ask pandas and DuckDB to do exactly the same things, so the settings for each step live in *one* place: the `cfg` dictionary. Both the pandas code and the SQL query read their columns, thresholds and limits from here, which guarantees that the two versions are asking for the same thing (and that the results are comparable).

```
cfg = dict(
    cols        = ['listing_url','price','number_of_reviews','property_type','host_n
    max_price   = 250,                  # for the 'constraint' step
    min_reviews = 0,
    ptype       = 'Entire home/apt',
    group_by    = ['room_type','property_type'],
    agg_price   = 1000,                 # for the 'aggregate' step
    limit       = 5,                    # rows to return
    reps        = 10,                   # repetitions for timing
)
tm = {}  # We'll store the timings here
```

And a helper that runs a function `reps` times and returns the average time (in seconds) as well as the last result:

```
def bench(fn, reps=cfg['reps']):
    t1 = time()
    for _ in range(reps):
        result = fn()
    return (time()-t1)/reps, result
```

2 Selecting Data in Pandas

In this section we are loading a parquet file using pandas and taking advantage of Python's 'chaining' functionality (`<object>.<method>().<method>()...`) to return the first few rows of a data frame using `head`. The thing to notice is that we're not even bothering to save the result of this command into a variable (thus the lack of a `df =` in the code): we're doing this *solely* so that you can compare pandas and DuckDB performance and syntax across each of the following steps.

2.1 A simple query

```
t, _ = bench(lambda: pd.read_parquet(pqt).head(3))
print(f"Average time per call: {t:.5f}")
```

I get an average time per call of about: 0.06751 seconds

```
    id                         listing_url last_scraped
264776 https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264776   2025-06-11             Huge Four Bedroom A
264777 https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264777   2025-06-11                  One Bedroom A
264778 https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264778   2025-06-11 Two Bedroom Newly Refurbished A
```

2.2 Selecting columns

To load a columnar subset of the data we have two options:

1. Load all the data and *then* subset (which always happens with CSV files but is optional with other formats)
2. Load only the columns we care about (which is possible with parquet files)

And in code these are implemented as:

2.2.1 Load *then* filter

```
t, _ = bench(lambda: pd.read_parquet(pqt)[cfg['cols']].head(cfg['limit']))
print(f"Average time per call: {t:.5f}")
```

I get an average time per call of about: 0.07154 seconds

```
                        listing_url  price  number_of_reviews      property_type host_r
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264776  297.0                 68 Entire rental unit
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264777   98.0                 24 Entire rental unit
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264778  148.0                 58 Entire rental unit
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264779  144.0                 36 Entire rental unit
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264780  157.0                 54 Entire rental unit
```

Not bad, not bad…

2.2.2 Filter *then* load

```
t, _ = bench(lambda: pd.read_parquet(pqt, columns=cfg['cols']).head(cfg['limit']))
print(f"Average time per call: {t:.5f}")
```

I get an average time per call of about: 0.00848 seconds

```
                        listing_url  price  number_of_reviews      property_type host_r
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264776  297.0                 68 Entire rental unit
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264777   98.0                 24 Entire rental unit
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264778  148.0                 58 Entire rental unit
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264779  144.0                 36 Entire rental unit
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264780  157.0                 54 Entire rental unit
```

Whoa! Notice the difference in the time needed to complete the operation! We just accelerated this step by 8.44 times.

2.3 Adding a constraint

So that is performance for loading data, now let's see what happens when we start subsetting the data by *row* as well as by *column*. Notice that we are using three conditions to filter the data *as well as* a column filter on loading to minimise the amount of data loaded into memory. Applying the filters simultaneously will also make it easy to see what you've done (you aren't applying each one separately) and to adjust the overall cleaning process.

```
def pd_filter():
    df = pd.read_parquet(pqt, columns=cfg['cols'])
    return df[
        (df.price < cfg['max_price']) &
        (df.number_of_reviews > cfg['min_reviews']) &
        (df.property_type == cfg['ptype'])
    ].head(cfg['limit'])
```

```
t, _ = bench(pd_filter)
print(f"Average time per call: {t:.5f}")
```

I get an average time per call of about: 0.00932 seconds

```
                          listing_url  price  number_of_reviews   property_type host_na
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/20433512  249.0                176 Entire home/apt     Nic
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/42969992  185.0                 29 Entire home/apt      Du
```

This filter is fairly straightforward and performance should have been only slightly slower than doing the column subset in the first place, but things get a bit more complicated when you want to aggregate the return…

2.4 Aggregating the return

There is a *lot* to unpack here, and notice that it takes several steps to achieve our goal of selecting, grouping, aggregating, sorting, and printing out the most frequent combinations of room and property type, although we *could* reduce it a bit if we really wanted to do so (at the cost of some legibility).

```
def pd_agg():
    df = pd.read_parquet(pqt, columns=cfg['group_by'] + ['number_of_reviews','price'
    df = df[
        (df.price < cfg['agg_price']) &
        (df.number_of_reviews > cfg['min_reviews'])
    ]
    return df.groupby(
        by=cfg['group_by'],
        observed=True
    ).agg(
        frequency    = ("property_type", "count"),
        median_price = ("price", "median"),
    ).reset_index().sort_values(
        by=['frequency'] + cfg['group_by'], ascending=[False,True,True]
```

```
    ).head(cfg['limit'])
```

```
t, res = bench(pd_agg)
print(f"Average time per call: {t:.5f}")
res
```

I get an average time per call of about: 0.01373 seconds

```
      room_type              property_type  frequency  median_price
Entire home/apt          Entire rental unit      20092         162.0
   Private room        Private room in home       5710          51.0
Entire home/apt                Entire condo       5314         158.0
   Private room Private room in rental unit       4971          61.0
Entire home/apt                 Entire home       4057         225.0
```

Hopefully the first two steps (load, filter) are fairly clear, so let's focus on the final ones.

Group By

This is a *reasonably* intelligible step in which we group the data loaded by room and property:

```
dfg = df.groupby(
        by=['room_type','property_type'],
        observed=True
    )
dfg
```

The *order* here matters: `groupby(by=[<A>,<B>])` does not return the same result as `groupby(by=[<B>,<A>])`. Try it:

```
df.groupby(
        by=['property_type','room_type'],
        observed=True
    )
```

The other thing to note here is the `observed=True`. This is a nice bit of additional functionality that, if you set it to `False` will return a number for all possible combinations, inserting a zero if that combination is *not* observed in the data. That's useful if *non*-observations (i.e. there was no data for this group) is relevant to your data presentation or subsequent modelling/statistical tests[1].

Agg

The `agg` step aggregates the data specified in the functions:

```
dfg.agg(
        frequency    = ("property_type", "count"),
        median_price = ("price", "median"),
```

[1] One could imagine, for instance, that you want to present the data in a table in which case you want the zero because there needs to be a value for each cell in the table.

```
)
```

Pandas offers a *lot* of different ways to do this, but the above approach is perhaps the most flexible since we are telling Pandas to apply the `count` function to the `property_type` field and assign it to a column called `frequency`, and to apply the `median` function to the `price` field and assign that to a column called `median_price`.

'Degroup'

In order to do anything further with the aggregated data you will *almost* always want to convert your `GroupedDataFrame` back to a regular `DataFrame` and that means resetting the index `reset_index()` – this is just one of those things to learn about grouped data in Pandas.

Sort

Finally, to sort the *data* you need to `sort_values`, where `by` specifies the fields you want to sort on and `ascending` is a matching (optional) list that specifies the sort order for each sort column. If you just want to sort everything in ascending order then you don't need to specify the `ascending` values, and if you wanted to sort *everything* in descending order then it's just `ascending=False`.

3 Selecting Data in DuckDB

That last example may have left you despairing of ever being able to select/filter/aggregate/derive your data, but there *is* another way that is often far simpler *if* you are: a) willing to learn a different language, and b) willing to work with data in different formats. And that's all thanks to Parquet and DuckDB.

The combination of parquet files and in-memory databases (DuckDB is just *one* of these) has fundamentally reshaped my workflow. Parquet and Apache Arrow are closely related but, in short, when you want to save large data sets in an easy-to-access and fast-to-query format then Parquet should be your default choice. DuckDB gives you a way to treat Parquet files *as* database **tables** and run queries against it (or them!) using standard SQL. You can install DuckDB on the command-line, but you can also query it from within Python using the `duckdb` module that we imported as `db` in the Preamble.

> ⚠ Make DuckDB do the work
>
> `db.sql(query)` does *not* run the query: it returns a lazy 'relation' that describes what you want. Nothing is read until you ask for the result, for instance with `.df()` (a pandas data frame). Every timing below therefore ends with `.df()`; without it you would be timing how long it takes DuckDB to *think about* the query, not to answer it.

3.1 A first query

Let's see a quick demonstration. The query is built with a multi-line f-string, so the file location (and, in the later queries, the settings from `cfg`) are filled in for us:

```
q_simple = f'''
SELECT *
FROM read_parquet('{pqt}')
LIMIT 3;
'''
```

```
t, _ = bench(lambda: db.sql(q_simple).df())
print(f"Average time per call: {t:.5f}")
```

I get an average time per call of about: 0.01946 seconds

```
    id                          listing_url last_scraped                                  
264776 https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264776   2025-06-11              Huge Four Bedroom A
264777 https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264777   2025-06-11                   One Bedroom A
264778 https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264778   2025-06-11 Two Bedroom Newly Refurbished A
```

Compare this with the pandas-only timing: when this page was built, pandas took 3.47 times as long as DuckDB. Treat that as a data point, not a rule: your number will differ, and both libraries keep changing, so the ratio will have moved (usually, but not always, in DuckDB's favour). Now let's unpack what's happening:

1. We set up a SQL `query` using a multi-line f-string.
2. We use DuckDB to execute the query and return a pandas data frame (`.df()`).

What's particularly elegant here (and quite different from trying to talk to a Postgres or MySQL database) is that there's no connect-execute-collect pattern; we just build the query and execute it!

> **i** I *do* declare…
>
> Now let's take a look at the SQL query… SQL is what's called a declarative language, meaning that it is about the logic we want the program to follow rather than the 'flow' of execution. Python supports *some* declarative elements but is more commonly seen as an imperative language supporting procedural or functional approaches. This is a long way of saying: SQL won't look like Python even though we're executing SQL from *within* Python.

So our query (with added line numbers for clarity) looked like this:

```
1 SELECT *
2 FROM read_parquet('<the parquet file>')
3 LIMIT 3
```

Line-by-line this means:

1. Select all columns (`*` == everything)
2. From the parquet file (`<table location>`)
3. Limit the return to 3 rows (`LIMIT <row count>`)

Let's look at some variations…

3.2 Selecting columns

```
q_cols = f'''
SELECT {', '.join(cfg['cols'])}
FROM read_parquet('{pqt}')
LIMIT {cfg['limit']};
'''
```

```
t, _ = bench(lambda: db.sql(q_cols).df())
print(f"Average time per call: {t:.5f}")
```

I get an average time per call of about: 0.00417 seconds

```
                        listing_url  price  number_of_reviews      property_type host_r
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264776  297.0                 68 Entire rental unit
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264777   98.0                 24 Entire rental unit
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264778  148.0                 58 Entire rental unit
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264779  144.0                 36 Entire rental unit
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/264780  157.0                 54 Entire rental unit
```

Compare this with the filter then load timing for pandas: when this page was built, pandas took 2.04 times as long as DuckDB. Again, check your own numbers.

```
SELECT listing_url, price, number_of_reviews, property_type, host_name
FROM read_parquet('<the parquet file>')
LIMIT 5;
```

It should be fairly easy to see how the query has changed from last time, but line-by-line this means:

1. Select a set of columns from the table in the order specified (`SELECT <column 1>, <column 30>, <column 5>...`)
2. From the parquet file (`FROM <table location>`)
3. Limit the return to 5 rows (`LIMIT <row count>`)

3.3 Adding a constraint

```
q_filter = f'''
SELECT {', '.join(cfg['cols'])}
FROM read_parquet('{pqt}')
WHERE price < {cfg['max_price']}
AND number_of_reviews > {cfg['min_reviews']}
AND property_type = '{cfg['ptype']}'
LIMIT {cfg['limit']};
'''
```

```
t, _ = bench(lambda: db.sql(q_filter).df())
print(f"Average time per call: {t:.5f}")
```

I get an average time per call of about: 0.00891 seconds

```
                          listing_url  price  number_of_reviews   property_type host_na
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/20433512  249.0                176 Entire home/apt     Nic
https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/42969992  185.0                 29 Entire home/apt      Du
```

Compare this with pandas: when this page was built, pandas took 1.05 times as long as DuckDB. If we wanted to be more rigorous about this we'd want to repeat the same operation many times (e.g. hundreds or thousands of times) to account for the fact that during any given query the computer might be doing other things that impact performance.

In this query we've added *three* constraints using a `WHERE`, which is asking DuckDB to find all of the rows *where* the following things are true:

1. The `price` must be less than ($)250/night
2. The `number_of_reviews` must be more than 0
3. The `property_type` must be `Entire home/apt`

(Those values come from `cfg`: change them there and *both* the pandas and the SQL versions change.)

3.4 Aggregating the return

That's hopefully enough to get you started on *selecting* data, but databases 'excel' at aggregating data in various ways. We aren't going to get into things like windowing functions or stored procedures here, but we can compare a simple aggregate in DuckDB with the pandas version above.

> **Tip**
>
> When you aggregate data you need to retrieve *every* column in the `SELECT` portion that you `GROUP BY` in the query. This will make sense when you see the examples below… and should also make sense based on the Pandas equivalent above!

```
q_agg = f'''
SELECT {', '.join(cfg['group_by'])},
    COUNT(*) AS frequency, MEDIAN(price) AS median_price
FROM read_parquet('{pqt}')
WHERE price < {cfg['agg_price']}
AND number_of_reviews > {cfg['min_reviews']}
GROUP BY {', '.join(cfg['group_by'])}
ORDER BY frequency DESC, {', '.join(cfg['group_by'])}
LIMIT {cfg['limit']};
'''
```

```
t, res = bench(lambda: db.sql(q_agg).df())
print(f"Average time per call: {t:.5f}")
res
```

I get an average time per call of about: 0.01088 seconds

```
      room_type              property_type  frequency  median_price
Entire home/apt        Entire rental unit      20092         162.0
```

```
   Private room        Private room in home       5710          51.0
Entire home/apt                 Entire condo       5314         158.0
   Private room Private room in rental unit       4971          61.0
Entire home/apt                  Entire home       4057         225.0
```

Here the result should be *identical* to the pandas one; when this page was built, pandas took 1.26 times as long as DuckDB (again: check your own numbers, which will have moved). Whatever the timings, I find the operation more clearly expressed in SQL than in pandas. There are quite a few changes to the query here so it's worth reviewing them in more detail:

```sql
SELECT room_type, property_type,
    COUNT(*) AS frequency, MEDIAN(price) AS median_price
FROM read_parquet('<the parquet file>')
WHERE price < 1000
AND number_of_reviews > 0
GROUP BY room_type, property_type
ORDER BY frequency DESC, room_type, property_type
LIMIT 5;
```

Key things to note:

1. We have two new aggregate *functions*:
    - `COUNT(*)` returns a count of the number of rows in each group specified in the `GROUP BY` clause. We don't need to specify a column here because `*` means 'all rows'.
    - `MEDIAN(price)` returns, unsurprisingly, the median value of the `price` column for *each* group specified in the `GROUP BY` clause.
    - *Note* also the `AS frequency` which 'renames' the column returned by the query; it's the same concept as the `import x as y` in Python.
2. `GROUP BY` is where the aggregation happens, and here we're asking DuckDB to take all of the rows selected (`WHERE price < 1000 AND number_of_reviews > 0`) and group them using the `room_type` and `property_type` fields.
3. `ORDER BY` orders the returned records by the columns we specify, and they can be either `ASC`ending (the default) or `DESC`ending (descending).

What you should also be noting here is that we have been able to express our selection, grouping, and organising criteria very succinctly. In terms of both speed and intelligibility, there can be quite substantial advantages to moving *some* of your workflow into a database or a database-like format such as Parquet and then querying that from Python. Databases are *designed* for the kind of application that Pandas struggles with, and if you get to windowing functions and stored procedures you'll see how there are situations where something is far easier to express in Python/Pandas than in SQL.

So the trick here is to recognise when you are facing a problem that: a) will benefit from being expressed/tackled in a different language; and b) won't create undue overhead on your technology 'stack'. In working with environmental and built environment data I was able to cut the processing time by 80% when I moved the bulk of the data linkage work from Pandas into Parquet+DuckDB. *But*, by the same token, what's the point of using Postgres and managing a spatial database to perform a single step in a much longer workflow *unless* the performance considerations are so massive they outweigh any other issue.

4 Thinking About Joins

We're going to look at joining data by attributes *first* and then look at spatial joins *after* so that you get a sense of how they behave and differ. However, even where you *do* have a spatial problem, it can be worth it to manage it as a non-spatial problem to improve the overall performance of your code.

For instance, say you have data from LSOAs and want to be able to aggregate it up to MSOA-level to perform various analyses.

LSOA Table

LSOA Code	Polygon
LSOA1	WKT(…)
LSOA2	WKT(…)
LSOA3	WKT(…)

MSOA Table

MSOA Code	Polygon
MSOA1	WKT(…)
MSOA2	WKT(…)
MSOA3	WKT(…)

The *obvious* way to do this is as a spatial join *something* like this:

```
SELECT m."MSOA Code", SUM(<attribute 1>) AS feature_sum, COUNT(<attribute 2>) AS fea
FROM <lsoa data table> AS l, <msoa data table> AS m
WHERE ST_Within(l.<lsoa geom>, m.<msoa geom>)
GROUP BY m."MSOA Code";
```

We'll get to what's happening with `AS l` and `AS lkp` in a bit more detail below, but the term for this is *aliasing* and its saves us having to repeatedly type `<lsoa data table>` by allowing us to use the alias `l`. But you would run this same query *every* time you wanted to aggregate something.

This is *not* the right way to tackle this problem even though you can write the query to give you the correct answer. Spatial queries (as I said in the pre-recorded lectures) are *hard*, so if you can 'cache' the result in a *non*-spatial format it will save a lot time in the future.

The answer is to run the spatial query *once* in order to create a 'lookup table' which uses the LSOA and MSOA *codes* (and you can even add Boroughs, Regions, OAs, and so on later if you like!) to tell you if a LSOA falls inside a borough or MSOA. So you perform the hard spatial query *just once* to create the lookup table, and thereafter you are using a fast non-spatial query.

In this case your lookup table will look like this…

Lookup Table

LSOA Code	MSOA Code	Borough Code
LSOA1	MSOA1	BORO1
LSOA2	MSOA1	BORO1
LSOA3	MSOA2	BORO1

Now you can do any kind of *spatial aggregation* you want without having to incur the costs of running a *spatial query* using something like:

```
SELECT lkp."MSOA Code", SUM(<attribute 1>) AS feature_sum, COUNT(<attribute 2>) AS f
FROM <lsoa data table> AS l, <lookup table> AS lkp
WHERE l."LSOA Code" = lkp."LSOA Code"
GROUP BY lkp."MSOA Code";
```

You can also use this as a foundation for creating a `VIEW` or a `[MATERIALIZED VIEW](https://www.databricks views)`, but that's an advanced topic for managing your data more efficiently in an operational environment rather than a research-oriented one.

> **Spatial DuckDB**
>
> DuckDB also now supports spatial queries via the `SPATIAL` extension. Performance is *not* that of a tuned Postgres+PostGIS database, but the overhead of *creating* such a tuned database often exceeds the benefit for ad-hoc querying. Basically, Postgres+PostGIS is great if you're a company such as Booking.com, Airbnb, or OpenStreetMap, but it's most likely overkill for offline, read-only applications.

4.1 Additional Data

For the rest of this notebook we need three data sets about MSOAs (which are statistical neighbourhoods that we'll treat as a proxy for 'real' neighbourhoods). The first two are *non*-spatial:

```
msoa_names_url = 'https://houseofcommonslibrary.github.io/msoanames/MSOA-Names-1.20.
msoa_popst_url = 'http://orca.casa.ucl.ac.uk/~jreades/data/sapemsoaquinaryagetablefi

msoa_nms = pd.read_csv( cache_data(msoa_names_url, 'data') )

# This one can't be cached because we need to access
# an Excel sheet name and the cache_data function isn't
# smart enough to handle this use case.
msoa_pq = Path('data/MSOA_population_estimates.parquet')
if msoa_pq.exists():
    msoa_df = pd.read_parquet(msoa_pq)
else:
    msoa_df = pd.read_excel(msoa_popst_url, sheet_name="Mid-2022 MSOA 2021", header=
    msoa_df.to_parquet(msoa_pq)

print(f"msoa_df  has {msoa_df.shape[0]:,} rows and {msoa_df.shape[1]:,} columns.")
print(f"msoa_nms has {msoa_nms.shape[0]:,} rows and {msoa_nms.shape[1]:,} columns.")
```

```
+ data/MSOA-Names-1.20.csv found locally!
msoa_df  has 7,264 rows and 43 columns.
msoa_nms has 7,201 rows and 6 columns.
```

We also need some geodata:

```
msoa_gpkg = gpd.read_file( cache_data(f'{host}/~jreades/data/MSOA-2011.gpkg', gdir)
```

```
+ data/geo/MSOA-2011.gpkg found locally!
```

> The preferred solution
>
> **To keep it simple**: you should assume that non-spatial joins are *always* going to be faster than spatial ones, even in a performant spatial database. Asking if one number is less than another, or if a piece of text is found in another piece of text, is *much* simpler than asking if one object falls within the boundaries of another. Spatial databases are fast and very cool, but if you can express your problem non-spatially it will be faster to solve it that way too.

5 Joining by Attribute

Pandas distinguishes between several types of what SQL would call a 'join': the process of linking two data sets. Depending on what you want to do, this will fall into one of the merge, join, concatenate, or compare functions:

- `concat` simply appends one data frame to another and won't be discussed further, but keep in mind that you can concatenate horizontally and vertically (across and down), and that having named indexes can cause consternation. You would find it most useful for appending columns to a data set (appending rows should be approached differently) or extending a data set for year n with data from year $n+1$…
- `merge` is what we normally want when we want to do something similar to a SQL join. You should refer back to the lecture for the differences between 'one-to-one', 'one-to-many', and 'many-to-many'. Note too that merging is a function of the pandas library and *not* a method of a data frame.

Our task is the same in both pandas and DuckDB: link the MSOA population estimates to the MSOA names so that we end up with the population of each MSOA in our Local Authority (`LA`). We'll keep the result because the worked example below needs it.

5.1 In pandas

The MSOA codes have (slightly) different names in the two data sets, so we need `left_on` and `right_on`:

```
rs = pd.merge(msoa_df, msoa_nms[['msoa11cd','msoa11hclnm','Laname']], left_on='MSOA
print(f"Result set has {rs.shape[0]:,} rows and {rs.shape[1]:,} columns.")
rs.head(3)
```

```
Result set has 7,264 rows and 46 columns.
```

	LAD 2021 Code	LAD 2021 Name	MSOA 2021 Code	MSOA 2021 Name	Total	F0 to 4	F5 to
0	E06000001	Hartlepool	E02002483	Hartlepool 001	10323	265	296
1	E06000001	Hartlepool	E02002484	Hartlepool 002	10460	325	349
2	E06000001	Hartlepool	E02002485	Hartlepool 003	8040	238	287

But wait! There's an issue lurking in the data!

```
print(f"There are {rs.msoa11hclnm.isna().sum()} missing MSOA Names!")
```

```
There are 184 missing MSOA Names!
```

Can you work out why this has happened? There is a clue in the column names! (The names data set uses 2011 MSOA codes (`msoa11cd`) while the population estimates use 2021 codes.) There's no way to solve this problem except by changing the code to use this URL instead for the MSOA Names; for the Local Authority we're working with, the codes mostly line up so we will carry on.

5.1.1 Constraining the join

We can constrain the result set to one LA thanks to data in the MSOA Names data set. Without the `how='inner'`, the result set would still have all of the rows but some of the columns would be nearly completely empty:

```
sdf = msoa_nms[msoa_nms.Laname==LA][['msoa11cd','msoa11hclnm','Laname']].copy()

la_pop_pd = pd.merge(
    msoa_df[['MSOA 2021 Code','Total']], sdf,
    left_on='MSOA 2021 Code', right_on='msoa11cd', how='inner')
print(f"Result set has {la_pop_pd.shape[0]:,} rows and {la_pop_pd.shape[1]:,} column
la_pop_pd.head(3)
```

```
Result set has 28 rows and 5 columns.
```

	MSOA 2021 Code	Total	msoa11cd	msoa11hclnm	Laname
0	E02000895	8363	E02000895	Chingford Green West	Waltham Forest
1	E02000896	9322	E02000896	Chingford Green East	Waltham Forest
2	E02000897	8438	E02000897	Friday Hill	Waltham Forest

5.2 In DuckDB

SQL-based joins use very similar keywords (since Pandas is 'copying' SQL), but how we put together the query is quite different. Here is the same join *and* the LA constraint in one query:

```
q_join = f'''
SELECT m.msoa11cd, m.msoa11hclnm, m.Laname, n.Total
FROM
    read_parquet('data/MSOA_population_estimates.parquet') AS n
INNER JOIN
    read_csv('{cache_data(msoa_names_url, 'data')}', header=true) AS m
ON
    n."MSOA 2021 Code"=m.msoa11cd
WHERE
    m.Laname='{LA}';
'''

la_pop_sql = db.sql(q_join).df()
print(f"Result set has {la_pop_sql.shape[0]:,} rows and {la_pop_sql.shape[1]:,} colu
la_pop_sql.head(3)
```

```
+ data/MSOA-Names-1.20.csv found locally!
Result set has 28 rows and 4 columns.
```

	msoa11cd	msoa11hclnm	Laname	Total
0	E02000895	Chingford Green West	Waltham Forest	8363
1	E02000896	Chingford Green East	Waltham Forest	9322
2	E02000897	Friday Hill	Waltham Forest	8438

And do the two approaches agree?

```
same = set(la_pop_pd.msoa11cd) == set(la_pop_sql.msoa11cd)
print(f"Both approaches return the same {la_pop_pd.shape[0]} MSOAs: {same}")
```

```
Both approaches return the same 28 MSOAs: True
```

Here is the SQL, line-by-line:

```
SELECT m.msoa11cd, m.msoa11hclnm, m.Laname, n.Total
FROM
    read_parquet('data/MSOA_population_estimates.parquet') AS n
INNER JOIN
    read_csv('<the names csv>', header=true) AS m
ON
    n."MSOA 2021 Code"=m.msoa11cd
WHERE
    m.Laname='Waltham Forest';
```

1. `SELECT` the columns we want (use `*` for every column). The `n.` and `m.` prefixes say which table each column comes from.
2. `FROM` the following tables (it doesn't really matter if the tables are on this line or the next for legibility)

3. `<table 1 from parquet> AS n` (we can now refer to the data from this table using the 'alias' `n.`; e.g. `n.Total`)
4. `INNER JOIN` as a concept was covered in the lecture; use `LEFT JOIN` to keep every row of the left table.
5. `<table 2 from csv> AS m` (we now refer to the data from this table using the alias `m.`; e.g. `m.Laname`)
6. `ON <left table matching column> = <right table matching column>` (here, the unusual thing is the double-quotes around the column name required to deal with the fact that the name contains spaces).
7. `WHERE` restricts the match to only those rows where the Local Authority name is the one we want.

Notice how there are parallels between even quite different languages here: if you have spaces or special characters or whatever in your column name then you're going to need to handle that a little differently, and if you have two tables to join you have a left (aka first) one and a right (aka second) one and the order matters.

However, for an inner join this query can *also* be written without the `JOIN` keyword:

```
q_join2 = f'''
SELECT m.msoa11cd, m.msoa11hclnm, m.Laname, n.Total
FROM
    read_parquet('data/MSOA_population_estimates.parquet') AS n,
    read_csv('{cache_data(msoa_names_url, 'data')}', header=true) AS m
WHERE m.Laname='{LA}'
AND n."MSOA 2021 Code"=m.msoa11cd;
'''

db.sql(q_join2).df().head(3)
```

```
+ data/MSOA-Names-1.20.csv found locally!
```

	msoa11cd	msoa11hclnm	Laname	Total
0	E02000895	Chingford Green West	Waltham Forest	8363
1	E02000896	Chingford Green East	Waltham Forest	9322
2	E02000897	Friday Hill	Waltham Forest	8438

The second way is a little easier to read, but it *only* allows you to do **inner joins** where attributes need to match in both tables for a row to be kept. This situation is such a common 'use case' that it makes sense to have this simpler syntax, but the previous code will work for inner, left, right, and outer joins.

> **Slower???**
>
> *Without* the data caching function, a query that reads a remote CSV may *appear* slower than the Pandas one but the time is mostly spent waiting for the file to download! Anyway, the download penalty is why I prefer to download a file *once* and save it locally rather than downloading the same file again and again. Plus it's friendlier (and cheaper!) to the person or organisation providing the data to you.

Finally, we keep just the columns that we need later. The worked example below joins this onto the MSOA geography:

```
la_pop = la_pop_pd[['msoa11cd','Total']].rename(columns={'msoa11cd':'MSOA11CD', 'Tot
la_pop.head(3)
```

	MSOA11CD	population
0	E02000895	8363
1	E02000896	9322
2	E02000897	8438

6 Spatial Joins in Geopandas

Let's try to find all of the listings that fall within the borough of Waltham Forest.

```
listings = gpd.read_parquet( cache_data(url, gdir) ).to_crs('epsg:27700')
```

```
+ data/geo/20260619-London-listings.geoparquet found locally!
```

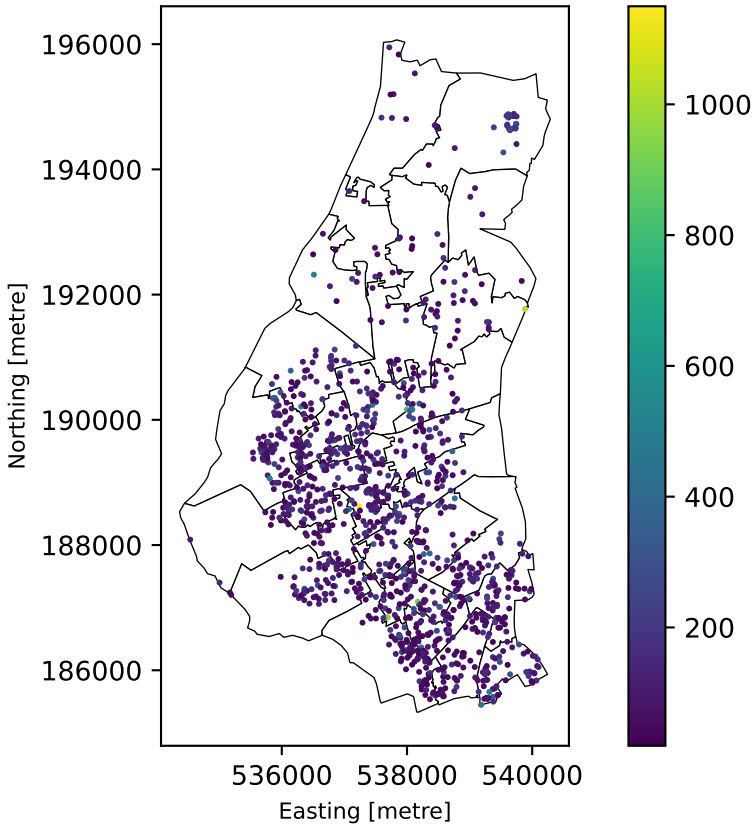
This query implies two steps:

1. Subset the MSOA geo-data so that it only includes the Waltham Forest MSOAs.
2. Run a spatial query to find the listings that are within those MSOAs (we could, optionally, `union` the MSOAs to get the outline of the borough)

```
boro_gdf = msoa_gpkg[msoa_gpkg.LAD11NM==LA].copy()

# Do the spatial join
boro_listings = gpd.sjoin(listings, boro_gdf, predicate='within', rsuffix='_r')

# Layer the plots
f, ax = plt.subplots(1,1,figsize=(8,5))
boro_gdf.plot(color="white", edgecolor="black", linewidth=0.5, ax=ax)
boro_listings.plot(column='price', cmap='viridis', legend=True, s=1.5, aspect=1, ax=
```



> **Warning**
>
> If you get `ValueError: aspect must be finite and positive` when you try to make a plot (this seems fairly common with `.gpkg` files) then you will need to specify `aspect=1` in the `plot(...)` command.

7 Spatial Joins in SQL

DuckDB can also do spatial joins through its `spatial` extension. Support has improved a lot recently and keeps changing, so rather than freezing a recipe in these notes we'll stick with GeoPandas and geoparquet for spatial work and leave the extension as a pointer for when you need to push a large spatial query outside of Python's memory. Whatever you do, remember the lesson from above: if you can turn a spatial problem into a non-spatial one (with a lookup table) then do so.

8 Worked Example

Let's now try work through a practical example that combines everything we've just learned.

8.1 Load Geodata

A lot of additional geo-data can be accessed from the GeoPortal. And see also my discussion on lookup tables. For demonstration purposes we're going to work the same set of files 'as

usual':

```
spath = 'https://github.com/jreades/fsds/blob/master/data/src/' # source path
water = gpd.read_file( cache_data(spath+'Water.gpkg?raw=true', gdir) )
boros = gpd.read_file( cache_data(spath+'Boroughs.gpkg?raw=true', gdir) )
green = gpd.read_file( cache_data(spath+'Greenspace.gpkg?raw=true', gdir) )
msoas = gpd.read_file( cache_data(f'{host}/~jreades/data/MSOA-2011.gpkg', gdir) ).to
```

```
+ data/geo/Water.gpkg found locally!
+ data/geo/Boroughs.gpkg found locally!
+ data/geo/Greenspace.gpkg found locally!
+ data/geo/MSOA-2011.gpkg found locally!
```

8.2 Select London MSOAs

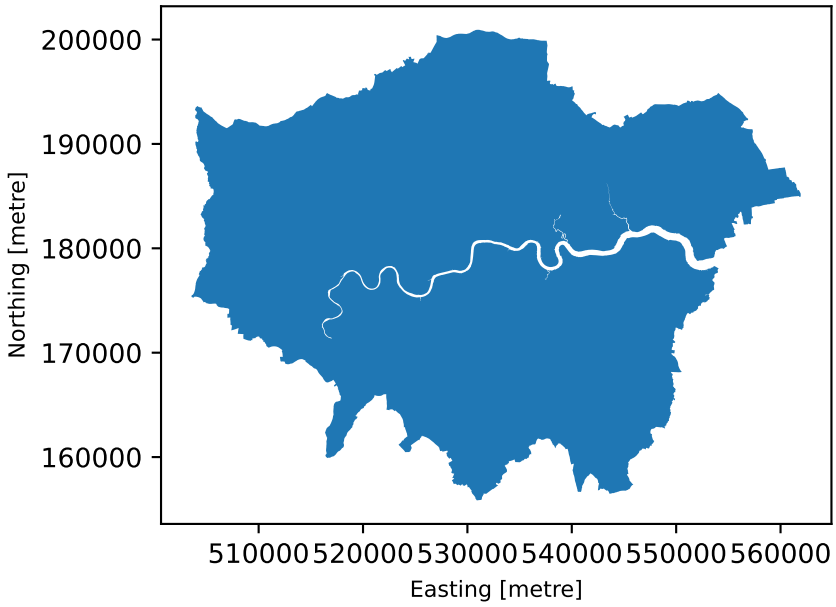
> **Connections**
>
> One thing to remember here is that computers are *exact*. So if you say that the selection should only be of MSOAs *within* London then you actually need to think about whether a shared border qualifies as 'within'. Watch the lectures again if you're unsure, but that's why here we take this slightly clunky approach of buffering the London boundary *before* doing the selection.

8.2.1 Union

As we don't have a boundary file for London, we can *generate* use using the `union` operator (as we do here) or using the dissolve() approach. Consider the pros and cons of each approach in terms of performance, output format, and legibility.

So here's approach 1, which is a method call returning a GeoDataFrame (which is why we can call `plot`):

```
boros.dissolve().plot();
```



And here's approach 2, which is an *attribute* and returns a raw polygon (so no reason to call `plot`, but it's come back without the rest of the data frame!):

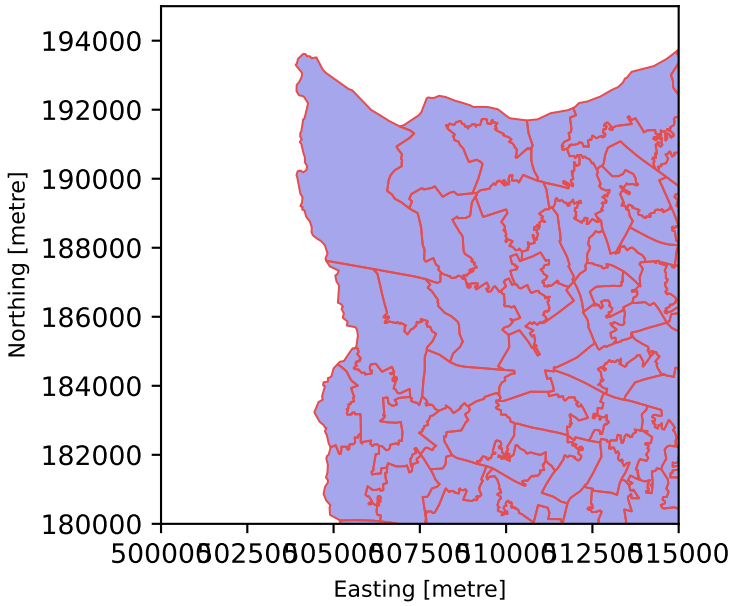
```
boros.union_all()
```



> **Connections**
>
> Notice how we're also demonstrating some additional ways of plotting 'on the fly' (without generating a data frame) as well as (below) showing you how to zoom in/out.

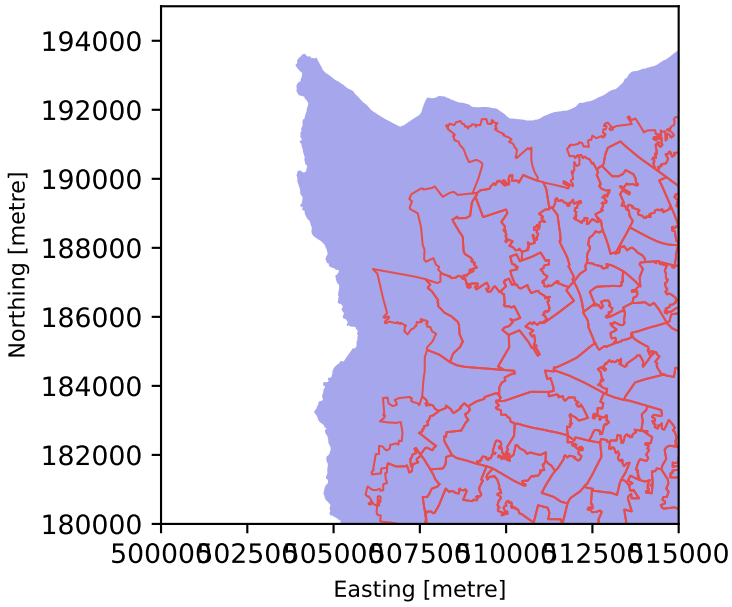
8.3 Selecting London MSOAs

```
ldn = gpd.GeoDataFrame(gpd.GeoSeries(data=boros.union_all())).rename(columns={0:'geo
ldn = ldn.set_crs(epsg=27700)
ax  = ldn.plot(facecolor=(.5, .5, .9, .7))
msoas.plot(ax=ax, facecolor='none', edgecolor=(.9, .3, .3), linewidth=0.75)
ax.set_xlim(500000, 515000)
ax.set_ylim(180000, 195000);
```



8.3.1 A (Bad) First Join

```
ldn_msoas = gpd.sjoin(msoas, ldn, predicate='within', how='inner')
ax = ldn.plot(facecolor=(.5, .5, .9, .7))
ldn_msoas.plot(ax=ax, facecolor='none', edgecolor=(.9, .3, .3), linewidth=0.75)
ax.set_xlim(500000, 515000)
ax.set_ylim(180000, 195000);
```



What has gone wrong???

Before you move on to the solution, stop and actually *think* about why this hasn't worked as you might (sensibly) have expected? This is another reason that you need to pay close attention to the differences between spatial and non-spatial joins.

8.3.2 Buffer and Join

In order to ensure that we get all the MSOAs *within* London we need to buffer the boundary by some amount to ensure that `within` returns what we want. If *cover* were easier to use then that option might be preferable.

Question

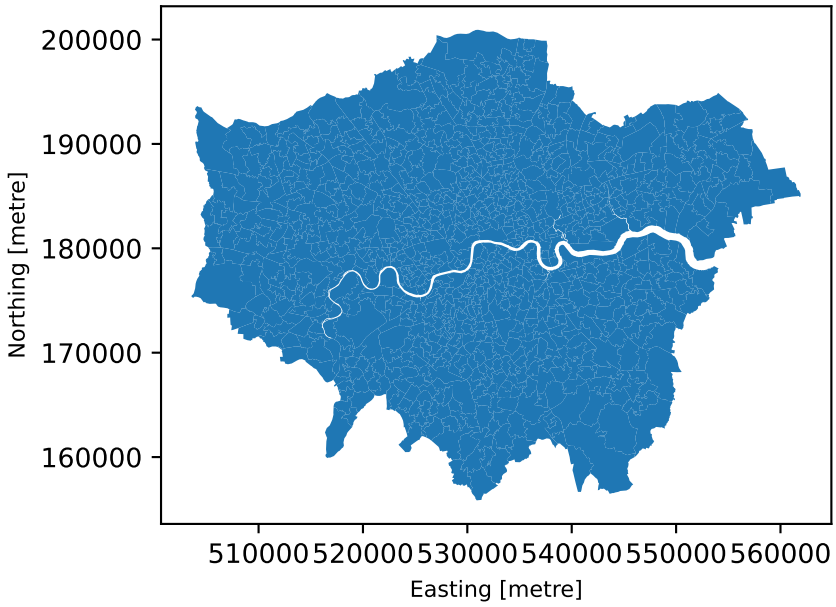
```
ldn['buffered'] = ldn.geometry.???(???)
ldn = ldn.set_geometry('buffered').set_crs(epsg=27700)
ax  = ldn.plot(facecolor=(.5, .5, .9, .5))
msoas.plot(ax=ax, facecolor='none', edgecolor=(.6, .6, .6, .6))
ax.set_xlim(500000, 515000)
ax.set_ylim(180000, 195000);
```

By default we want do an *inner* join because we want to drop everything that doesn't line up between the two data sets (i.e. don't keep the thousands of *other* non-London MSOAs).

Question

```
ldn_msoas = gpd.sjoin(msoas, ldn, predicate='???', how='inner')
ldn_msoas.plot()
```

Your result should be:



The join leaves behind two columns that we don't need (the index of the matching London row and London's own geometry), so drop them before going any further:

```
ldn_msoas = ldn_msoas.drop(columns=['index_right','geometry_right'], errors='ignore'
```

8.3.3 Important Note

If your plot above looks like the output from `pandas` and not `geopandas` then the list of columns and the documentation for `set_geometry` might help you to understand what is going wrong:

```
print(", ".join(ldn_msoas.columns.to_list()))
```

```
MSOA11CD, MSOA11NM, LAD11CD, LAD11NM, RGN11CD, RGN11NM, USUALRES, HHOLDRES, COMESTRES,
```

It's important to recognise that `join` and `sjoin` are *not* the same even though they may effectively perform the same function. An issue can arise if we join two *geodata* frames using the join function from `pandas`. The latter doesn't know anything about spatial data and we can therefore 'lose track' of the geometry column. *Worse*, there are actually two geometry columns now, so we need to tell Geopandas which one to use!

The easiest way to do this is to simply rename the geometry we *want* and then set is as the active geometry. Here's the code to use if you have a `geometry_left` column and aren't able to show a map:

```
ldn_msoas = ldn_msoas.rename(columns={'geometry_left':'geometry'}).set_geometry('geo
ldn_msoas.drop(columns='geometry_right', inplace=True)
```

We also no longer really need to keep the full MSOA data set hanging about.

```
try:
    del(msoas)
except NameError:
```

```
    print("msoas already deleted.")
```

Question

- Can you explain *why* the outputs of the `dissolve` and `union_all` *look* differnet? And use that as the basis for explaining why they *are* different?

  Answer 1

- How do you know that the units for the buffering operation are metres? 250 could be *anything* right?

  Answer 2

- Why do we need to buffer the London geometry *before* performing the *within* spatial join?

  Answer 3

8.4 Create Borough and Regional Mappings

We don't actually make use of these in this session, but *both* operations could be relevant to your final reports:

1. The Borough-to-Subregion mapping could help you to group your data into larger sets so that your resulst become more reobust. it also connects us to long-run patterns of socio-economic development in London.
2. The MSOA Names data set (which you used above) gives you something that you could use to label one or more 'neighbourhoods' on a map with names that are *relevant*. So rather than talking about "As you can see, Sutton 003, is…", you can write "The Wrythe area of Sutton is significantly different from the surrounding areas…"

They also usefully test your understanding of regular expressions and a few other aspects covered in previous weeks.

8.4.1 Replace

You've done this before: notice that the MSOA Name *contains* the Borough name **with a space and some digits at the end**. Use a regex (in `str.replace()`) to extract the LA name from the MSOA name. See if you do this *without* having to find your previous answer!

Question

```
ldn_msoas['Borough'] = ldn_msoas.MSOA11NM.str.replace(r'???','',regex=True)

# Just check results look plausible; you should have:
# - 33 boroughs
# - A df shape of 983 x 14
print(ldn_msoas.Borough.unique())
print(f"There are {len(ldn_msoas.Borough.unique())} boroughs.")
print(f"Overall shape of data frame is {' x '.join([str(x) for x in ldn_msoas.shape]
```

8.4.2 Map

Now that we've got the borough names we can set up a `mapping` dict here so that we can apply it as part of the `groupby` operation below (you should have 33 keys when done):

```
mapping = {}
for b in ['Enfield','Waltham Forest','Redbridge','Barking and Dagenham','Havering','
    mapping[b]='Outer East and North East'
for b in ['Haringey','Islington','Hackney','Tower Hamlets','Newham','Lambeth','South
    mapping[b]='Inner East'
for b in ['Bromley','Croydon','Sutton','Merton','Kingston upon Thames']:
    mapping[b]='Outer South'
for b in ['Wandsworth','Kensington and Chelsea','Hammersmith and Fulham','Westminste
    mapping[b]='Inner West'
for b in ['Richmond upon Thames','Hounslow','Ealing','Hillingdon','Brent','Harrow','
    mapping[b]='Outer West and North West'
print(len(mapping.keys()))
```

```
33
```

Question

```
ldn_msoas['Subregion'] = ldn_msoas.Borough.map(???)
```

8.4.3 And Save

```
ldn_msoas.to_parquet(gdir / 'London_MSOA_Names.geoparquet')
```

8.5 Spatial Join

Associate LA (Local Authority) names to the listings using a spatial join, but **notice** the `how` here:

Question

```
gdf_la = gpd.sjoin(listings, ???, predicate='???', how='left')
print(gdf_la.columns.to_list())
```

8.5.1 Tidy Up

```
gdf_la.drop(columns=['index_right','HECTARES','NONLD_AREA','ONS_INNER'], inplace=Tru
```

You'll need to look closely to check that the `value_counts` output squares with your expectations. If you don't get `33` then there's an issue and you'll need to run the code in Section 8.5.2:

```
if len(gdf_la.NAME.unique()) == 33:
    print("All good...")
else:
    print("Need to run the next section of code...")
    print(f"Now there are... {len(gdf_la.NAME.unique())} boroughs?")
    gdf_la.NAME.value_counts(dropna=False)
```

```
All good...
```

8.5.2 Find Problematic Listings

If you were told that you need to run the next section of code then see if you can work out what happened…

```
try:
    print(gdf_la[gdf_la.NAME.isna()].sample(2)[['name', 'NAME']])
    ax = gdf_la[gdf_la.NAME.isna()].plot(figsize=(9,6), markersize=5, alpha=0.5)
    boros.plot(ax=ax, edgecolor='r', facecolor='None', alpha=0.5);
except ValueError as e:
   pass
```

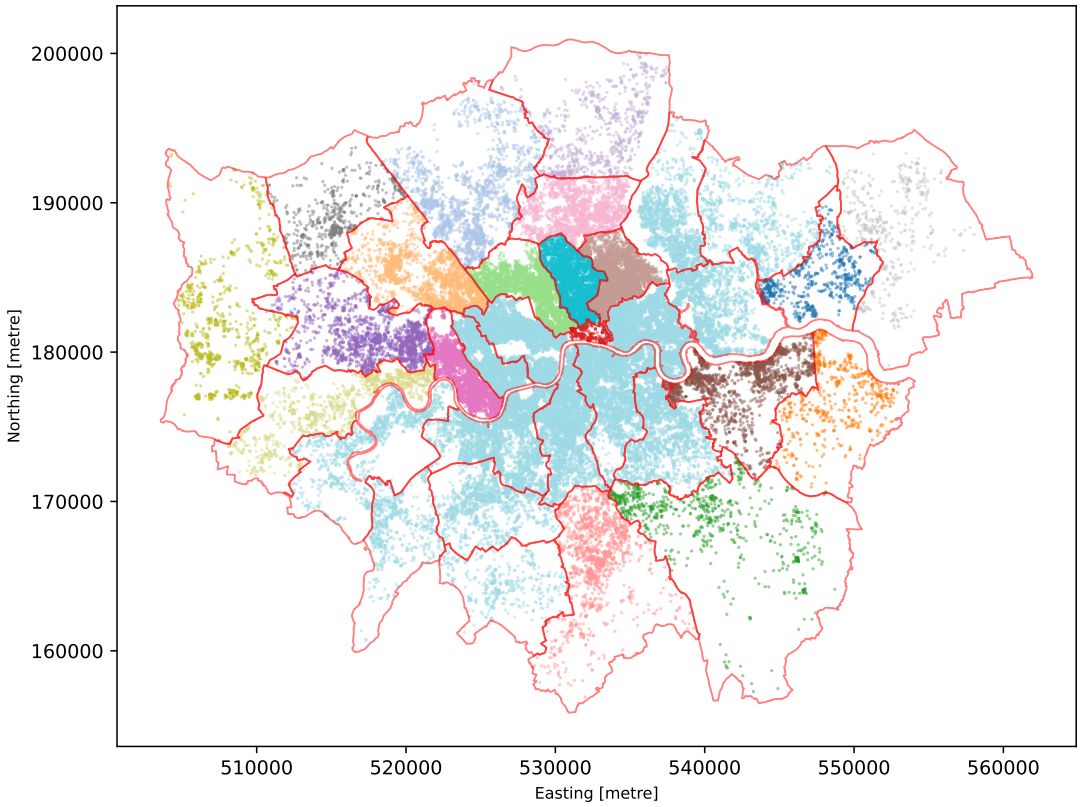
In short: in some cases there may be records that fall outside of London because of Airbnb's shuffling approach:

```
gdf_la.drop(index=gdf_la[gdf_la.NAME.isna()].index, axis=1, inplace=True)
print(f"Data frame is {gdf_la.shape[0]:,} x {gdf_la.shape[1]}")
```

8.5.3 Check and Save

```
ax = gdf_la.plot(column='NAME', markersize=0.5, alpha=0.5, figsize=(9,7))
boros.plot(ax=ax, edgecolor='r', facecolor='None', alpha=0.5);
```

You should get the following:




```
gdf_la.to_parquet(gdir / 'Listings_with_LA.geoparquet')
```

Question

- Do you understand the difference between `how='inner'` and `how='left'`?

8.6 Create LA Data

Now that we've assigned every listing to a borough, we can derive aggregate values for different groups of zones.

8.6.1 Select LA

We use the Local Authority (`LA`) set in the Preamble. Change it there if you want to explore a different borough.

8.6.2 Spatial Join

The first thing we want to do is join MSOA identifiers to each listing. In both cases we want to constrain the data to only be for 'our' LA of interest since that will speed up the process substantially:

```
gdf_msoa = gpd.sjoin(
            gdf_la[gdf_la.NAME==LA].reset_index(),
            ldn_msoas[ldn_msoas.Borough==LA][['MSOA11CD','MSOA11NM','USUALRES','HHOL
gdf_msoa.head(2)
```

	index	id	listing_url	last_scraped	name
0	30	276082	https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/276082	2025-06-13	Bright Clean Double Room-Ch
1	45	41870	https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/41870	2025-06-13	Room in relaxed family house!

8.6.3 Aggregate

Now aggregate the data by MSOA, deriving median price and a count of the listings:

```
grdf_msoa = gdf_msoa.groupby('MSOA11NM').agg(
    listing_count = ('price','count'),
    median_price = ('price','median')
).reset_index()
print(f"Have {grdf_msoa.shape[0]:,} rows and {grdf_msoa.shape[1]:,} columns")
grdf_msoa.head(2)
```

```
Have 28 rows and 3 columns
```

	MSOA11NM	listing_count	median_price
0	Waltham Forest 001	11	95.0
1	Waltham Forest 002	31	158.0

8.6.4 Join (Again)

Here we see the **difference between merge and join**. You'll notice that `join` operates by taking one data frame as the implicit '*left*' table (the one which *calls* join) while the one that is passed to the join function is, implicitly, the '*right*' table. Join operates only using indexes, so you'll need to insert the code to specify the same index on both data frames, but this can be done **on-the-fly** as part of the joining operation:

```
msoa_gdf = grdf_msoa.set_index('MSOA11NM').join(
                ldn_msoas[ldn_msoas.Borough==LA].set_index('MSOA11NM'),
                rsuffix='_r').set_geometry('geometry')
msoa_gdf.head(3)
```

MSOA11NM	listing_count	median_price	MSOA11CD	LAD11CD	LAD11NM	RGN1
Waltham Forest 001	11	95.0	E02000895	E09000031	Waltham Forest	E1200
Waltham Forest 002	31	158.0	E02000896	E09000031	Waltham Forest	E1200
Waltham Forest 003	4	89.5	E02000897	E09000031	Waltham Forest	E1200

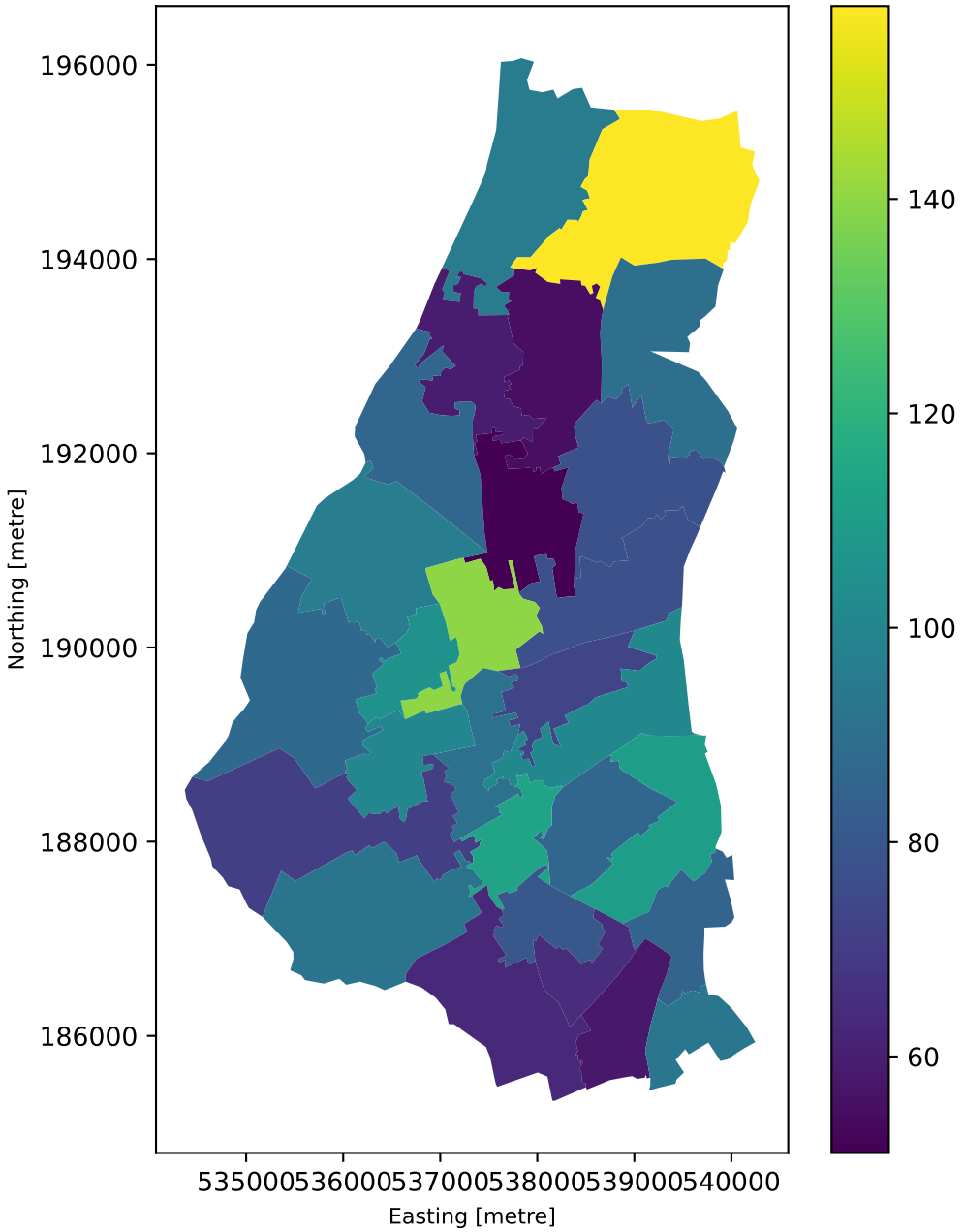
And now we can bring back the population data that we linked by attribute earlier (`la_pop`) to see how busy each neighbourhood is relative to its size. A `merge` returns a GeoDataFrame here, so the geometry is preserved:

```
msoa_gdf = msoa_gdf.reset_index().merge(la_pop, on='MSOA11CD', how='left')
msoa_gdf['listings_per_1000'] = 1000 * msoa_gdf.listing_count / msoa_gdf.population
msoa_gdf[['MSOA11NM','listing_count','population','listings_per_1000']].head(3)
```

	MSOA11NM	listing_count	population	listings_per_1000
0	Waltham Forest 001	11	8363	1.315317
1	Waltham Forest 002	31	9322	3.325467
2	Waltham Forest 003	4	8438	0.474046

```
msoa_gdf.plot(column='median_price', legend=True, figsize=(8,8));
```

You should get something like:



8.6.5 Save

Just so that we can pick up here without having to re-run all the preceding cells.

```
msoa_gdf.to_parquet(gdir / f'{LA_slug}-MSOA_data.geoparquet')
```

Question

- Do you understand the differences between `pd.merge` and `df.join`? and `gpd.sjoin`?

- Do you understand why it may be necessary to `set_geometry` in some cases?